what we mean when we say that people are talking and acting politically.

In this concluding chapter of *Conflict in Myanmar,* I read the preceding chapters alongside these three terms — politics, the political, and the nonpolitical. Working through the contributions of my coauthors and with an eye to conflict, my aim is to go some way towards addressing the question of what it means to talk and act politically in Myanmar today, and specifically, how we might differentiate the political from its others. I begin with politics, then the nonpolitical, and lastly, gesture to the promise of the political. I conclude by reflecting upon what threats, in view of the book's contents, the political in Myanmar today encounters.

POLITICS

The lack of political aptitude in Myanmar's military partly explains why it has never been much good at dealing with conflict. It does, of course, excel in violence (see Cheesman 2014a, p. 342). All militaries are violence specialists, and the one in Myanmar has had more opportunities to develop its specialty through armed combat than most.

But if Clausewitz was right that in war politics continues by other means, it is a means that departs from politics, and passes over into some other domain than the political. People may go to war on account of politics, but victory on the battlefield is not ultimately determined politically. Rather, it is determined strategically.

For the longest of times, Myanmar's soldiers favoured strategic solutions to conflict. Violence was their ubiquitous response to antagonism. When meeting intransigent violence, it would be foolhardy to insist on a political response. Consequently, for many people in areas subjected to decades of military violence, political action is implausible. Instead, people in these places respond to their need for security through strategic actions of their own (see Cathcart 2016).

Even where the army did enter negotiations with armed opponents in the 1980s, 1990s and 2000s it treated them not as opportunities for political dialogue, but as a kind of cattle trading. Individual armed groups and commanders who agreed to ceasefires negotiated directly with the military and got moneymaking opportunities, and the army off their back. Most, like the Pa-O National Organisation (see Yue 2016), retained their weapons and a degree of administrative autonomy in the areas where they were